

IRTG Newsletter

Issue # 01 – May 2025



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Editor's Note

Welcome to the inaugural edition of the IRTG Newsletter!

We are pleased to introduce this new platform, created to foster stronger connections, increase visibility of ongoing work, and share helpful information across our diverse international research group.

Each issue will bring you curated updates on current events, opportunities, achievements, and resources relevant to your journey as a doctoral researcher.

We hope this newsletter serves as both a practical guide and an encouraging companion through the exciting – and sometimes challenging – landscape of academic life.

Highlights of This Edition

- **News** – Updates and announcements from the current IRTG cycle.
- **New Members** – Get to know some new faces in our IRTG community.
- **Events & Deadlines** – An overview of upcoming events and important deadlines to mark in your calendar.
- **Graduate Spotlights** – Celebrating our members who have recently graduated or are about to complete their journey with the IRTG.
- **Useful Contacts & Important Links** – Key people and portals you'll want to have at your fingertips.
- **Miscellaneous** – Practical tips, community contributions, and a lighthearted note to wrap things up.

We invite you to explore the sections below for full details and thank you for being an active part of our vibrant community.

Who We Are: IRTG within SFB-TRR195

The **International Research Training Group (IRTG)** provides structured academic training and support for doctoral researchers. It is embedded within the transregional **Sonderforschungsbereich (SFB-TRR 195)** – a collaborative research center funded by the **Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft (DFG)** (German Research Foundation) – which focuses on symbolic tools in mathematics and their applications.

The IRTG enriches the SFB's mission by cultivating a vibrant research and learning community across its core locations in Aachen (RWTH), Kaiserslautern (RPTU), and Saarbrücken (UdS), with additional collaboration from Berlin, Darmstadt, Siegen, Stuttgart, and Tübingen. For more information, visit the [DFG project page](#).

News

Stay informed about what's happening across the IRTG. The following updates cover recent news, events, and announcements.

New Speakers for the IRTG

As we enter the new and final funding period of the SFB (2025 – 2028), there has been a change in leadership: **Moritz Weber** has succeeded **Roland Speicher** as speaker. The IRTG is now jointly led by **Gabriele Nebe (Aachen)** and **Moritz Weber (Saarbrücken)**.

Junior Speakers for the IRTG

To facilitate better communication between Ph.D. researchers and the steering committee, each main location has elected a **junior speaker**. Among them, two serve as **general representatives** for all IRTG doctoral researchers. The current junior speakers are:

- **Firoozeh Aga (née Dastur)** (General Representative),
- **Annika Bartelt** (Local Representative, Kaiserslautern),
- **Tobias Braun** (Local Representative, Aachen & General Representative),
- **Friedrich Günther** (Local Representative, Saarbrücken).

DFG project ID

If the SFB funds your research, please make sure to cite the DFG **Project ID 286237555** in all your publications – including journal articles and your Ph.D. thesis.

New IRTG Members

Please join us in welcoming our newest members to the group!

We encourage everyone to reach out – whether in person or online – to exchange ideas, share expertise, and build meaningful connections.

- **Ibrahim Ahmad** (RWTH), Aachen
- **Marco Albert** (RPTU), Kaiserslautern
- **Friedrich Günther** (UdS), Saarbrücken
- **Nina Kiefer** (UdS), Saarbrücken
- **Stefan Lippert** (University of Siegen), Siegen
- **Fabian Mäurer** (RPTU), Kaiserslautern
- **Benjamin Mirgain** (UdS), Saarbrücken
- **Clemens Nollau** (University of Tübingen), Tübingen
- **Luca Remke** (Stuttgart University), Stuttgart
- **Björn Schäfer** (UdS), Saarbrücken
- **David Schlang** (RWTH), Aachen
- **Michael Schlößer** (RWTH), Aachen
- **Wilken Steiner** (University of Siegen), Siegen

Events & Deadlines

Keep track of the important dates and events coming your way – details follow below.

Internal Grant Proposal

Until **May 15th**, the application for small grants in the context of IRTG is open for everyone. Contact **Moritz Weber** for more details about the application and the grant.

Next IRTG Seminar

Join us for the next **IRTG Seminar**, which will be held on **June 13th** in **Kaiserslautern** and available **hybrid**. The seminar will be organized by **Diego Robayo Bargans**, and will include a **soft skill seminar**. More details will follow soon.

Summer School: Computer Algebra with Oscar

Mark your calendars for the **Summer School on Computer Algebra with OSCAR**, taking place in **Lambrecht** from **September 15th to 19th**. This is a fantastic opportunity to become proficient in using the **OSCAR computer algebra system** for your research. [Register here](#) by **August 15th**.

IRTG Block Seminar

The **IRTG Block Seminar** will take place in **Saarbrücken** from **September 1st to 3rd**. Dive into **compact Riemann surfaces** and their connection to **smooth projective curves**. The seminar will also sketch the relationship to **Teichmüller curves**. [Register here](#) to secure your spot.

Annual Meeting of the SFB

The **Annual Meeting of the SFB** will be held in **Tübingen** from **September 22nd to 25th**. For more information, visit the [official website](#). **Note:** The registration deadline has already passed.

Graduate Spotlights

Cheers to those who have completed their studies or are on the brink of graduating. Find out more below!

Defended Theses

- **Diego Robayo Bargans (RPTU), Kaiserslautern**
Successfully defended his thesis on **March 6th**.
- **Marie Roth (RPTU), Kaiserslautern**
Defended her Ph.D. thesis on **March 5th**.
She will begin a **postdoctoral position in Norwich, UK** starting **June**.

Theses Submitted – Remaining in the SFB

- **Liam Rogel (RPTU), Kaiserslautern**
He has submitted his thesis and will continue in the SFB as a **postdoc for one year**.
- **Tobias Braun (RWTH), Aachen**
He has submitted his thesis and will remain as a **postdoc for two more years**.

Upcoming Defense

- **Stevell Muller (UdS), Saarbrücken**
Scheduled to **defend on May 27th**.
Currently based in **Hannover**, and will be **leaving the SFB** thereafter.

Useful Contacts

Whether you're seeking advice or need help navigating your Ph.D., these IRTG members are here to help. Please feel free to reach out to them with any questions or concerns.

General Management

- **Dr. Michael Kunte** (General Manager)
email: michael.kunte [at] math.rptu.de

- **Barbara Ermisch** (Secretary)
email: barbara.ermisch [at] math.rptu.de

IRTG Senior Speakers

- **Prof. Dr. Gabriele Nebe**
email: nebe [at] math.rwth-aachen.de
- **Prof. Dr. Moritz Weber**
email: weber [at] math.uni-sb.de

IRTG Junior Speakers

- **Firoozeh Aga (née Dastur)** – General Representative
email: firoozeh.aga [at] edu.rptu.de
- **Annika Bartelt** – Local Representative (RPTU), Kaiserslautern
email: bartelt.a [at] rptu.de
- **Tobias Braun** – Local Representative (RWTH), Aachen & General Representative
email: tobias.braun2 [at] rwth-aachen.de
- **Friedrich Günther** – Local Representative (UdS), Saarbrücken
email: guenther [at] math.uni-sb.de

Mediators

If you encounter any difficulties, conflicts, or challenges within the group, our mediators are available to offer neutral, confidential support. You may contact any of them regardless of your local affiliation.

- **Prof. Dr. Claus Fieker**
(RPTU), Kaiserslautern
email: claus.fieker [at] rptu.de
- **Prof. Dr. Hannah Markwig**
(University of Tübingen), Tübingen
email: hannah[at]math.uni-tuebingen.de
- **Prof. Dr. Ghislain Fourier**
(RWTH), Aachen
email: fourier[at]art.rwth-aachen.de

- **Prof. Dr. Gabriela Weitze-Schmithüsen**
(UdS), Saarbrücken
email: weitze [at] math.uni-sb.de

Gender Equality and Diversity (GED) Committee

The GED Committee is committed to fostering an inclusive, equitable environment for all members. It consists of both senior and student representatives who advocate for fairness and provide a safe space for dialogue.

Senior Representatives:

- **Prof. Dr. Gabriela Weitze-Schmithüsen**
(UdS), Saarbrücken – Committee Chair
email: weitze [at] math.uni-sb.de
- **Dr. Thomas Breuer**
(RWTH), Aachen
email: thomas.breuer[at]math.rwth-aachen.de

Student Representatives:

- **Firoozeh Aga (née Dastur)**
(RPTU), Kaiserslautern
email: firoozeh.aga [at] edu.rptu.de
- **Marie Roth**
(RPTU), Kaiserslautern
email: m.roth [at] math.rptu.de

For any support or inquiries, please feel free to contact the committee members via email. For more details, please visit the **Gender Equality & Diversity (GED) webpage**.

Important Links

Below you'll find a selection of important links related to the SFB and the IRTG. We encourage you to subscribe to the relevant mailing lists to stay informed and connected.

SFB-TRR 195

Stay informed about the structure and activities of our SFB:

- **Official Project Details:** Find the official project description and project number on the **DFG website**.
- **General Information and Events:** Bookmark **computeralgebra.de** for updates on projects, upcoming events, and internal news related to the SFB.
- **OSCAR System:** The computer algebra system **OSCAR** is developed within our SFB. Learn more and get support through the **OSCAR contact page**.
- **Gender Equality & Diversity (GED) Committee:** To explore the ongoing work of our GED committee, visit the dedicated **GED webpage**.

Integrated Research Training Group (IRTG)

As a Ph.D. student, you are part of the IRTG, our graduate programme is designed to support your research and development:

Visit the **IRTG information page** to learn more about its structure, resources, and upcoming opportunities.

Mailing Lists

Stay informed through our official mailing lists, where important dates and events are shared. We encourage all members to subscribe.

- **Graduate Students:** **Register here** to receive updates relevant to Ph.D. students.
- **Members and Associates:** Join the **general mailing list** for broader SFB news.
- **GED Announcements:** If you identify as part of an underrepresented group or are interested in equality and diversity topics, consider subscribing to the **GED mailing list** for relevant updates and opportunities.

Messenger App

In addition to official channels, a more informal platform is maintained by fellow IRTG members to stay connected:

Signal Group: Join our **Signal group** to chat with current and former IRTG members, ask quick questions, and hear community news.

Miscellaneous

As we close this issue, we've included a few additional highlights, helpful resources, and a touch of mathematical humor to end on a lighter note.

IRTG-Seminar Coordinator

Wilken Steiner (University of Siegen) will coordinate the **IRTG seminars** for the **Winter Semester 2025** and **Summer Semester 2026**. If you're considering contributing or have ideas to share, you're warmly encouraged to reach out to him via one of the contact channels mentioned above.

Counseling and Well-being Services

Your **mental well-being** is just as important as your academic progress. Below are links to **mental health resources** and **support services** at our partner universities. Whether you're seeking counseling, crisis support, or general well-being guidance, these pages provide valuable resources **from each university**.

- **Aachen: Center for Mental Health & Psychological Counseling** – Explore supportive counseling services and well-being options at RWTH Aachen University.
- **Kaiserslautern: Mental Health First Aid for Students & Local Support Structures for Employees** – Access resources for counseling and well-being for students and employees at Kaiserslautern University.

- **Saarbrücken: Counseling Services** – Find counseling and well-being resources at Saarland University.
- **Siegen: Counseling Services** – Explore psychosocial support services at the University of Siegen.
- **Stuttgart: Psychotherapeutic Counseling** – Access psychotherapeutic services for mental well-being at the University of Stuttgart.
- **Tübingen: Counseling Services** – Find resources for counseling and well-being at the University of Tübingen.

The Project Ö

A short message from the **Project Ö** team, who are dedicated to increasing OSCAR's visibility within the computer algebra community.

The Project Ö is dedicated to making OSCAR more prominent in the Computeralgebra community. It is lead by Moritz Weber (weber[at]math.uni-sb.de) and Ghislain Fourier (fourier[at]art.rwth-aachen.de).

One key point is sending two PhD-Students of the TRR, called the "OSCAR-Ambassadors" to broad Computeralgebra conferences to give an introductory talk and make people interested.

Currently, Lars Göttgens (goettgens[at]art.rwth-aachen.de) is one of them while the other position is still to be filled. For more specialized conferences, we rely on you (aka the people that work in that special field and users of OSCAR) to talk about your research and how it uses OSCAR.

In case of any questions, please contact the above people.

Thank you!

AI's Witty Perspective

To wrap things up, I couldn't help but ask AI for a joke about my work as a mathematician. Here's the response:

Why did the tropical geometer win the math debate?

Because while others chased smooth solutions, they cornered every argument with piecewise precision! 😎🌴

Get Involved: Contribute to the Newsletter!

Do you have something you'd like to share with the IRTG community? Whether it's announcing a seminar, promoting an event you're organizing, showcasing your work, or seeking assistance, reach out to one of the junior speakers to be featured in the next newsletter!

Acknowledgment

We would like to express our appreciation to the senior speakers and IRTG management for their continued support, and to our fellow IRTG members for electing us as junior speakers. This inaugural newsletter is our first step toward fostering better communication and creating a shared space for voices within our community.

Editorial Team

Chief Editor:

Firoozeh Aga (née Dastur) – steered the editorial process, managing content flow and final review, ensuring coherence, readability, and accessibility for readers from diverse backgrounds.

Editorial Supporters:

Tobias Braun – played a key role in gathering content and performing initial proofreading, contributing to the refinement of the final material.

Annika Bartlet, Friedrich Günther – were instrumental in collecting valuable content and supporting the development of the overall narrative of the newsletter.